The message was stopped before the money moved.

A senior user in India received an email claiming a scholarship and cash prize had been **"officially verified"** — if a processing fee was paid first. He paused, forwarded it for checking, and paid nothing. This is that check, with its receipts.

SCAM	Rs 55,000	Rs 1,999	Rs 0	Same morning
VERDICT	PROMISED IN THE EMAIL	FEE DEMANDED FIRST	PAID BY THE USER	FORWARD TO WARNING

WHAT HAPPENED — THE LOOP THAT WORKED

1 The pause

The email arrived from an address styled to look official. Instead of paying, the user forwarded it to a trusted contact.

> *"Please verify and advise."*

2 The check

The email, the sender's own website, and the live payment page were checked against each other — not taken at face value.

3 The verdict, with reasons

A clear verdict came back: scam — do not pay, do not reply, do not share bank, UPI, card, or OTP details.

4 The warning, in his language

A calm warning was sent back in Marathi — why it was a scam and what to do next. No shame, no panic, one clear next step if anything had already been paid or shared.

EVIDENCE — THE SENDER CONTRADICTED ITSELF

× **A government look, a private address**

The sender used a "gov@" address on a private domain — not a government domain. The official appearance was the costume.

× **Pay first to release your own prize**

Rs 31,200 scholarship plus Rs 23,800 cash prize would arrive "within 4 hours" — but only after a Rs 1,999 "reduced processing fee." The classic advance-fee structure.

× **Results that had not happened yet**

The sender's own website said results for the season would publish on 3 November 2026 and evaluation was still in progress. A winner notice on 2 November did not fit its own timeline.

× **A prize and a fee that appear nowhere**

The website listed different prizes — Rs 1,51,000, Rs 1,00,000, Rs 75,000, and Rs 5,000 — and a Rs 149 registration fee. Neither the Rs 55,000 prize nor the Rs 1,999 fee appeared anywhere on it.

× **A live payment page built to lower guard**

The payment link was live for exactly Rs 1,999, described as "mandatory" and "fully refundable." Its displayed registration number did not match the real format, and no independent trace of the organisation was found outside its own site.

WHAT THIS PROVES

The brain works today. Cross-checking a message against its sender's own claims and its payment page stopped this scam — no new app, no training, no skill required beyond pausing and asking.

THE ASK FOR META

Make the pause the default. Put this check inside the message, at the moment it arrives, so every user gets a bouncer — not only those with a trusted contact to forward to.

Bob the Bouncer — a pause-and-verify check for suspicious messages.

Anonymised live case | Amounts and dates as shown in the original message